

# THE CHRISTMAS SCANDAL

\* Blue denotes PPT slide

\* Brown denotes instructions to technician

**TEXT:** Matthew 1:18-21 *“Now the birth of Jesus Christ was as follows: After His mother Mary was betrothed to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child of the Holy Spirit. 19 Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not wanting to make her a public example, was minded to put her away secretly. 20 *But while he thought about these things, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, “Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take to you Mary your wife, for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit. 21 And she will bring forth a Son, and you shall call His name Jesus, for He will save His people from their sins.”**

**INTRO:** Christmas is a time when our in-laws and outlaws gather, and all of us have come away from such meetings with knowledge of a scandal brewing in the family, more times than we would care to admit!

## **I. CHRISTMAS BEGAN WITH A SCANDAL!**

*Matthew 1:18 (NKJV) “Now the birth of Jesus Christ was as follows: After His mother Mary was betrothed to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child...”*

Put yourself in Joseph’s shoes! His fiancée’ has obviously been unfaithful to him.

Imagine:

- The hurt...
- The disbelief...
- The disillusionment...

Mary probably did her best to explain the whole thing to him, but he is having none of it and furthermore does not intend to have anything to do with this child!

This is biblical drama at its zenith!

In this life, none of us are exempt from scandal:

- Self-inflicted scandal... (Stupid stuff we have done)
- Second-hand scandal... (Associated with someone who does something wrong – Enron workers)
- Third-party scandal... (Family and friends having a brain freeze)

## **II. THE LONG TERM EFFECTS OF A SCANDAL DEPENDS ON HOW WE DEAL WITH IT...**

Here is the key phrase in this story...

[Matthew 1:19 \(NKJV\) “\*Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not\*](#)

*wanting to make her a public example, was minded to put her away secretly.”*

As you will see, according to the law Joseph had several options available to him in dealing with this scandal. Joseph had already decided how he would handle this before the angel appeared.

Without the actions of a just man, the story would have a completely different outcome. When scandal hits our lives do we possess the ability to handle it in a just manner? (Perverted justice is what we see in our world)

Joseph's first reaction was to reject her! Put her away and therefore have nothing to do with this immoral woman who had hurt him so deeply. He was completely within his rights to do so.

How many times in our lives, when God is up to something, do we reject it because it is not comfortable? This is often how we miss what God is doing! What God is up to is often outside our understanding and the norm. We think we know what's up, but we really don't.

I'm sure Joseph felt his life was officially in a tailspin! The angel had not yet confirmed to him that the conception of this child was different. In his mind, Mary has cheated on him! How humiliating! How embarrassing!

God must often resort to unconventional means in order to make an entrance into our lives!

- Our jobs... (The loss of a job or a transfer)
- Our plans... (Interrupt our plans with a life-altering event)
- Our family... (A health or family crisis often causes us to look to God)

- Our marriage... (The threat of divorce often causes people to stop and pay attention in a relationship)

Are we willing to allow Christ to be revealed in each area of our lives or must we go through a scandal of some kind for HIM to get our attention?

Can you see the fingerprints of God in your current situation? *“Trouble isn’t trouble if it brings you to God.”*

Joseph had the right according to the Old Testament law, to not only put Mary away, but to have her killed! **Leviticus 20:10 (ESV)** *“If a man commits adultery with the wife of his neighbor, both the adulterer and the adulteress shall surely be put to death.”*

I want you to think about this, now. It’s not just the life of Mary hanging in the balance

here, Gods plan for the ages hinges on what this just man will decide!

When our circumstances push our buttons and life becomes difficult, how will we react? There are times when Heaven is at work and it feels like hell is prevailing!

### **III. THE IMPORTANCE OF LISTENING TO THE VOICE OF GOD WHILE EMBROILED IN A SCANDAL!**

Stephen Covey a modern day leadership authority talks about the time between what happens TO us and our RESPONSE. He says, *“Imagine a pause button between what happens to you and your response—a button you can engage to pause and think about what is the principle-based response to your given situation.”* The Bible refers to this button as a Selah moment – *“Pause and think calmly.”*

Joseph hits the pause button. His first reaction is to put her away so that she won't be killed or humiliated. This reaction is why the Bible declares him to be a just man. Are we wired to exercise justice in our scandals.

Joseph keeps his RESPONSE on hold while all these emotions are still churning. In the middle of the PAUSE, God presents a third option, - ***“Take Mary as your wife! Cover the (Perceived) sin - Cover the scandal - keep her from disgrace!”*** In the court of public opinion Joseph was as guilty as Mary, but Joseph knows full well that he has had nothing to do with this. According to the law, if he marries her, this whole thing goes away. In marrying her he can never escape the whispering of the people for the rest of his life.

What is it in our lives that we need to hit the pause button on? Maybe we need to stop long enough to allow God to speak. Maybe

we're about to make a bad decision, maybe we're about to make a GOOD decision, but God wants to tell us the BEST decision if we will just PAUSE!

When our current situation brings ridicule; loss of time, energy and money; do we have the character to turn:

- Discredit into credit?
- Disgrace into grace?
- Dishonor into honor?
- Humiliation into a hallelujah?

The outcome of our scandal hinges on whether we are people of justice and character. Character restrains us! It causes us to consider the consequences of our decisions, not just for ourselves, but others.

Character is the voltage regulator on our power gift!

Joseph's character allowed him to look past the perceived infidelity of Mary and into her future and consider the outcome of his decision. Sure Mary had hurt him, but his decision could have been to have her killed to make himself look good.

## **CONCLUSION:**

Consider this: Is there a situation in your life right now that causes you pain, hurt, fear, rejection, or anger? Do you feel violated? In the midst of this current scandal I encourage you to stop and consider a different course of action that might allow God to facilitate an outcome that you have not yet considered. [\*Matthew 1:20-21 \(NKJV\) “But while he thought about these things, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, “Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take to you Mary your wife, for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit. 21 And she will bring forth a Son, and you shall call His\*](#)

*name Jesus, for He will save His people from their sins.”*

This whole story follows a progression from rejection to embrace. Why? Because Joseph took the high road and didn't react immediately, rather he paused long enough to hear God speak. Once he heard from the angel his life became one of obedience.

*Matthew 1:24-25 (NKJV) “Then Joseph, being aroused from sleep, did as the angel of the Lord commanded him and took to him his wife, 25 and did not know her till she had brought forth her firstborn Son.[d] And he called His name Jesus.”*

As a result of Joseph's patience during the biggest scandal of his life the greatest miracle in the history of the world became a reality! The incarnation of Christ:

- God's Son became Mary's Baby...
- A child was born, but a son man was given....

- The Lion of the Tribe of Judah became a lamb slain from the foundation of the world... (From everlasting to everlasting – Eternal Priesthood after the order – Before Abraham was, I am)
- An equal to God became a lowly servant of all mankind...
- The Ancient of Days became an infant born in the stable of Bethlehem...
- The Omnipotent became a dependant life to be fed, clothed and nourished by human hands...
- He placed himself in the hands of man, that man might place himself in the hands of God... (Cast ourselves upon the mercies of God – His mercies are new every morning)

What good thing is God planning to inaugurate at the conclusion of this current mess we are presently embroiled in? We must pause and allow His justice to use our

***“Light afflictions to work for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory.”***